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Derrick Gardner

Trumpeter and composer Derrick Gardner has displayed his talents in the Count Basie Orchestra, the Harry Connick Jr. Big Band, and the Smithsonian Jazz Masterworks Orchestra. He leads and records with his own sextet, the Jazz Prophets, and is currently a professor of jazz performance at the University of Manitoba.

Derrick was interviewed in Clinton, NY, on May 9, 2013, by Monk Rowe, director of the Hamilton College Jazz Archive.

MR: We are in the Jazz Archive at Hamilton College and I'm very pleased to have Derrick Gardner with me today, trumpeter, educator, composer. Does that do it?

DG: Yeah. That about does it.

MR: I have to say that I'm envious of one of your accomplishments.

DG: Oh boy.

MR: And that is you've written charts and had the Count Basie Orchestra play them.

DG: Yeah.

MR: Now that, I mean, people dream about that you know.

DG: Yeah, yeah. It was early in my arranging career you might say. When I first joined the band, in 1991, Frank Foster was directing the band. And in between cities on the bus he'd be sitting at the front of the bus in his seat with a pad of manuscript paper a chart for big band instrumentation, and a black felt-tipped pen, and with no piano or anything you know. And he was doing saxophones [scats]; trumpets [scats]; trombone [scats]. And I was thinking about him doing that and I said wow, that's pretty slick man I think. I thought I wonder if I can do that. I got some ideas about writing, about a tune I wanted to arrange you know. And so I bought a big pad of score paper, manuscript paper, got my pencil, and I said [scats] and I wrote about eight to ten measures or something you know. And I figured, I said, man I've got one of the greatest arrangers in the history of this music at arm's length distance to me. I've got to learn something from him. So after I wrote out my few little measures I went to the front of the bus about a couple of weeks later and I said, "Hey, Fos, would you kindly take a look at this and see if I'm on the right path here you know." He said, "okay." And he took it and looked at it and he says "um hum, um hum" and he took his cap from his black pen and he went "um hum," grabbed his red pen took the cap off and he said "okay that's all wrong, and this should be a B natural instead of B flat, and why'd you put a G sharp there that shouldn't be G sharp, and make that a G natural. And this thing" he caught a flat five here. "Why'd you put a flat five here when you've got a sharp five, don't do that, that's gonna clash in this

chord." And he kind of did the Zorro thing, I don't know, but he said, "Check that out." And I looked at it and he basically just bled all over my page. I said, "okay." So we were basically back on the bus and I touched my leg and said "whew." So we got to the hotel, and fortunately the hotel had a piano. And I played through all the corrections he made, you know, I said okay, I see, oh wow, boy, I sure was off in my thinking here, wow. And so the next thing I did was I bought a little keyboard, you know, and about a month later I wrote about ten or twelve measures or something you know. And we're on the bus and I went to Fos and said, "hey, Fos, would you take a look at this?" And so he took the cap off to the red pen and he says "well that's okay. These ones here, now that's wrong, you should do it like this." Each time, so I'd bring it back to him, so he said "okay," and each time I went back to him I had less blood on my page, you know. And so I just went off of his instruction and started learning some of the voicings that he uses and applied them to what I do, and because of that, wow it was like a graduate, a doctorate course in big band arranging, and totally, I mean viable, the information that he gave me.

MR: And this is pre-Finale or Sibelius or anything?

DG: This was just around the time that Finale was starting to raise its head I guess. Matter of fact, it was — Finale came a few years later. There was a program called Music Printer Plus. That might have been the first one.

MR: But did you eventually get — you wrote something and then the band played it?

DG: Oh no. That didn't happen for maybe another two years from the first time I went to the front of the bus and showed Fos my arrangement, you know. And that was like passing out an arrangement to the Basie band was like going before the Supreme Court, you know? "Wow man I don't know if this is going to work, man, this isn't Basie. No, it's not going to work, toss it." It took me years, like what? Man. But the Basie band, that's how they kept their sound. They were very strict as far as not letting just anything be played by them. And so I learned the Basie sound, the equation for what is a Count Basie arrangement. Because Count Basie wasn't an arranger, actually he was hardly a human composer — a handful of tunes that were made into arrangements. His arrangers were like Frank Foster and Thad Jones and Jim Mundy, Nestico and I'm leaving out somebody.

MR: Neal Hefti.

DG: Neal Hefti. All these and then a few others. Quincy Jones.

MR: Ernie Wilkins.

DG: Ernie Wilkins, yeah, oh man, Ernie Wilkins. So those were the people who formed the Basie sound. And when they brought in an arrangement to the band, oh it was even worse then. Because that's when Basie was alive it was in its heyday. And that's when Basie would kind of carve up the arrangement and say "that section right there, on the bridge

there, the horns you all lay out, I'm gonna take that." Oh big old — you know it could be like this thick orchestrated thing, you know, all this counterpoint, all this other stuff, and Basie says "cut it out, I'm gonna take that." What?

MR: And can you just picture after all that. I mean here you are like yeah, Basie's band playing my stuff. And then it's like yeah, but.

DG: Yeah. Throw that out, I'm gonna take that. And after he would do his surgical thing on an arrangement then he would say okay. Now that's Basie. And the arrangement would be what it is.

MR: That's great. Well you grew up in Chicago.

DG: Yeah.

MR: And was there a point, a definite point in your life that you said music, that's it for me; that's going to be my career.

DG: Yeah. As a matter of fact it's funny, I just answered that question earlier today in Doc's history class. And it was around the time when I was about maybe a junior in high school that I said I think music is the direction I'm going to go. Both my parents are musicians and educators as well. My father is a jazz trumpeter and he was in the Ray Charles band back in the early sixties, with Hank Crawford and Marcus Belgrade and all those guys, and "Fathead" Newman. And my mother is a classical pianist and organist and choir director. So growing up in Chicago I kind of got it from both ends. You know my mother would be practicing the classical music upstairs, and then down in the basement was my father's practice room and he'd be swinging, playing Cannonball. And I was taking piano lessons at five years old. My mother had me take piano lessons, and practicing these very simple beginning piano etudes or whatever. And I eventually got bored with it, after three or four years of doing it. And I finally decided upon, after hearing my father's music, I said "I want to play that." You know, "you want to play jazz?" "Yeah, I want to do that." I didn't know the piano could do that. You know? And so my elementary school started a band program and I was nine years old. And they said "who wants to join the band?" And I said "I want to join the band." And they said "what do you want to play?" "I want to play the trumpet." "Well we don't have a trumpet, what about this clarinet over here?" "No, trumpet." They said "well we don't have a trumpet." So I said "I'll take care of this." So I ran home and said, "Daddy, I want to play the trumpet." "Really?" So he had a trumpet for me. So I showed up the next day with a trumpet. You know and the rest is kind of history I guess.

MR: What do you think, well some people talk about a significant big break or somebody took extra time with you and that caused a good shift for you. Was there a moment like that for you?

DG: That would have to be the time when I joined the Basie band. As fate would have it, my mother got me the gig. Can you imagine that? My mother at the time was chairperson of the music department at Hampton University in Hampton, Virginia. And I was in grad school at Indiana University with Mike Woods. What happened was the Count Basie band was looking for a school to archive Basie's stuff, music, other items, whatever, they were looking for a school. He chose Hampton. And with that they wanted to set up an annual jazz festival and a series of master classes and clinics for an entire week there at the school. And when they were doing the meetings for that, to discuss all the specifics, they had a trumpet chair open. And they asked my trumpet teacher that was there at the time, his name was Bob Ransom, a fabulous trumpeter. And he said they says "there's a chair open, you want to try out for the band?" He said, "no man, I'm too old for that, going out on the road." "Dr. Gardner, you got Dr. Gardner's son, he's ready, he's ready to go out." And my mother was like "yeah, I'll call him right now." So after the meeting she called me and said "look, you're going to get a call from the Count Basie orchestra, they're going to call you to go out on the road." I said, "Mom, what have you been smoking? How would you even have connections within those circles?" So she explained the whole thing you know. I said, wow, really, okay. So the next day I got a call from Aaron Woodward, who was Count Basie's adopted son. And he was in control of the orchestra as far as its bookings, and he owned the band basically. And he was in those meetings at Hampton. And so he called me and talked to me and kind of interviewed me on the phone I guess. And then later that night I got a call from Frank Foster. And the phone was like this in my hand. I said "oh Mr. Foster," you know. And so we had a chance to talk and he told me to send him a tape of my playing and everything. Back then we were using tapes. Cassette tapes you know. So I sent him a cassette tape of my playing. And he heard it and got back to me and said "boy you're a great player, man. Come on. We're ready for you." And I left in, that was January of '91 when I left. And my first gig was in Newark, New Jersey at some function there. And I didn't know, I thought I had the gig basically. I didn't know that the first gig was the audition, you know. So I had left school and everything and pulled up roots. And I met them in New Jersey at the gig and then after the gig was over he said, "all right kid, well you played pretty good, I guess you can have the gig." I said, "I thought I already had the —." He said, "that was the audition, man, you didn't have this gig." Oh goodness.

MR: I can see you calling the Registrar. That's a good story. And were you basically sight reading, or you knew some of the music?

DG: Well yeah. I knew some of the music, but the Basie band has their own way of playing what is written on the page, which makes the band sound particularly unique. And for instance there's a piece in there, an Ernie Wilkins' piece called "Right On Right On."

And it's figured a quarter rest followed by four eighth notes, eighth rest, followed by an eighth note tied over. And so I saw it and I said [scats]. So we got to it and this is the B shout section, right, you know. And so we get to it and the whole band goes [scats]. And I'm going [scats].

MR: Do you guys have the same music that I do?

DG: [scats] Okay, wow. But you could say everybody was just kind of looking at me because they knew — they knew coming up to that that there's no pre-instruction that that's going to happen. So I'm going [scats] and out of the corner of everybody's eyes it's like — like that you know. Well thanks guys for telling me this, you know. And then the hardest piece in the book, I always say this, was "L'il Darlin'" because of the breath control. "L'il Darlin'" and Thad Jones' piece called "To You." Both are very similar ballads. With "L'il Darlin'" they have this phrasing and breathing thing in part of the melody where again it's written one way and it's played another way. You know the tune is [scats]. You know like that. And so moving on to [scats]. But I'm like [scats]. And I'm looking at the page and I said why that's a natural breath to take right there. Oh, okay, this is the way that they do it. It totally blew my mind, first that you could do that, and also that everybody in that band breathed and phrased like one person. I mean everybody. And if a new person comes into the band you could tell it, and he or she's going to be out of place because the phrasing is so exact and so unique. So yeah, that was definitely a revelation in my musical life.

MR: Yeah, as I said, I'm jealous. Well then to jump ahead a few years. What's it like, you have this group called the Jazz Prophets.

DG: Yeah.

MR: What's it like these days to try to keep a core of musicians together to carry out a project like that. Everybody is, by necessity, probably doing multiple things, including yourself. Is it hard?

DG: Oh it's extremely difficult. Without the financial backing of a record label — but there are ways around that as well — or the support of a publicity team, or a booking agent/manager, those type of supporting figures, an IT person for your website, you know, all those things. And it took me a long time to figure out that that's what was needed. And I finally got to have a few of those pieces in place. It's still very difficult to find work for the ensemble, or the type of work that I would like to have, that pays for everything. You know, it pays for the travel, the lodging, and all the other specifics, and the musician fees as well. And so those are the jobs that I'm holding out for. I could work quite a bit more but the money wouldn't be right and the travel situation wouldn't be right, hotels wouldn't be right. That would have to come out of my pocket too, to cover some of those expenses so I'd just end up losing a lot of money. And I've seen it work for

many other artists who carry their own bands and so that's what I'm trying to do, to do the same thing on my own. And I'm pretty close to figuring it out. In the meantime I just have to work in this kind of sporadic schedule where there's maybe two or three gigs that we do per year come through everything that's in place and everything is right.

MR: I saw a quote from your website that had to do with introducing new music to the jazz genre. Do you feel that's part of your goal, your mission?

DG: Oh without a doubt. Without a doubt you know. You can only play "All the Things You Are" but so many times you know, along with all the other great standards that have been put out there. And there are even a lot of tunes by — preexisting tunes that haven't been played a lot, tunes like a tune by Miles Davis and Wayne Shorter, who wrote "ESP" on that Miles Davis record; or other Wayne Shorter stuff like "El Gaucho" by Herbie Hancock or Gigi Gryce or anybody you know. But nonetheless, we have something to say, within the Jazz Prophets as composers. And I use that sextet in order to provide a vehicle for that. And we have three CD's out and actually one more is in the can, of new music. And so in order for the music to continually progress I believe that you have to keep adding to the genre in order to just keep it fresh. You know, the kind of the musical concept of my group is heavily steeped in the hard bop tradition you know. Because of our instrumentation we kind of, it's very easy for us to kind of come out of the Art Blakey and the Jazz Messengers kind of a format, although we don't do any of that music because of the texture of the — because of the instrumentation, the texture kind of sounds the same with the trumpet, trombone and tenor saxophone, but we change that texture quite a bit, sometimes I have — on the tenor saxophone is Rob Dixon, we have him playing an alto or soprano saxophone, and even sometimes having my brother Vincent playing euphonium, you know, and me playing the trumpet or flugelhorn, changing the texture of it. And we're writing in a different vein than was done during the hard bop era. So in keeping with this new era I guess that some historians have called neo-traditional or neo-classic jazz or whatever, you know, there's a lot of new music out here you know. And it's good music. We wouldn't play it unless it was good you know.

MR: I want to see if this will work for me. I want to ask you about something here.
[audio interlude]
So you've heard this before?

DG: I think I've kind of heard this before.

MR: So where does the idea come from for a song like that.

DG: It can come from anywhere. It can come from any and all directions. Sometimes you hear the melody first, sometimes you hear a chord progression first, sometimes you hear a rhythmic beat that might influence it. I've written pieces from all directions. That particular piece came from a voicing that Frank Foster showed me on the piano for a big

band, or a saxophone section voicing, that's very spread out. As a matter of fact it's fifths between the baritone, second tenor, and then fifths between the first tenor, second alto and lead alto. And then you fit the trombones in between the spaces there. It's a real big, thick sounding chord. And so he was showing me this voicing for the saxophones and I was checking it out and I said man, that's nice. And then I kind of started moving things around here and said wait a minute, what's this? And I said oh, oh, I like this. So I wrote a tune based off of that voicing, added a melody to it you know. And there was another tune that I wrote from a particular rhythmic beat or feel, that a wonderful friend of mine that I used to teach with at the Michigan State University, his name is Randy Gillespie, one of the unsung legends on drums. I mean this guy sounds like Roy Haynes or Art Blakey or any of them, or Elvin Jones. He used to be the drummer with Sonny Stitt and Wes Montgomery back in the day. And he was teaching drums at Michigan State. And we were on this gig one time and he started playing this particular beat that was just as significant as say you know the beat on Ahmad Jamal's "Poinciana?" You know? Something as significant. It's different but it's as significant as that. And he broke it out. We were trading, and I did my four bars trading, and he broke out this beat. And I said man what is that? And he just smiled at me you know, and said "yeah, I got you here." So after the gig I said "man, do that thing you were doing when we were trading fours." And so he explained to me that when he was playing with — the organist, I can't think of the organist's name — they were playing Atlantic City. And they were opening for Jimmy Smith. Gene Lovey. He was playing with Gene Lovey. And they were opening for Jimmy Smith. And they were covering a Ray Charles tune or something. And he said he broke out this beat, and he said all of a sudden the crowd got up and started dancing and everything and getting all hyped and everything. And then he played that thing for an hour. I said wow man. And then after he finished Jimmy Smith came over to him and said "I don't know why they got us coming on, y'all done burned up the stage, man. We can't play after that."

MR: Nice.

DG: But I wrote an entire tune based off of that beat, and I called it "Soulful Brother Gillespie." And I even expanded it into a big band arrangement. So that's to say I've composed off of many influences, from something like that or I might hear the melody first. I wrote a tune on my first CD the title track is called "Slim Goody." And I heard that melody while I was on the subway when I was living in New York, I was traveling on the subway to visit my girlfriend at the time. And it was before cell phones. And so I heard this melody in my head. But I was right in the middle of my journey uptown you know. And I said I can't forget this melody. So I just started singing it to myself you know, and people started looking at me on the subway — nobody talks about anybody

strange on the subway. So when I got to my subway stop I went to a pay phone and called my answer machine and sang it into the answer machine so I wouldn't forget it. Because you know you'll think of something like at night when you go to sleep and your mind is open. And — man I really like that melody, okay, when I get up tomorrow I'm going to write it down. And you get up the next morning and say what was that thing I thought about last night, and it's gone. You can't even think about it.

MR: Well it kind of brings me to a question and I'm not sure how to ask it. But does music for you, or especially in your own compositions, does it have to mean something? Does it have to have a subtext or can it just be music?

DG: I think that there is music that can be written to be functional, you know, that serves a purpose. Like I was just talking to Doc Woods about this earlier today. He was talking about writing for films. And the music has to convey a mood and not take away from the dialogue that's being conveyed in the film. Or background music at a restaurant, you know, it serves a purpose. But when you're composing music to be really listened to, concertized music, or even when you're improvising, I'm one that believes that you have to move people you know, and you have to give your listeners something that's going to keep that person engaged the entire time, or dialed in you know. And in that respect I do believe that music has to mean something. You know there are certain techniques that people use that can, you can say okay well I'm going to write what's called a contrafact over "All the Things You Are." You know you erase the melody, the chord changes are still there, and you just write a new melody. Okay, simple enough. Even when you're doing that, that melody has to mean something. You know like Kenny Dorham did that with "All the Things You Are." He wrote — well now I can't think of the name of the tune — [scats]. Oh I can't think of it. I'm sure that whoever listens to this, everyone probably knows it. But when I listen to that, that's not music that I would listen to as like background music or elevator music or something. That music is engaging. And so that's what I try to do every time I perform, I try to engage my listener. And every time I write I try to engage my listener in the same way that I improvise, I try to convey that on the score paper when I'm writing. And there are certain ways that you do that, manipulate the voicings or the tension. I always try to move people.

MR: I had to chuckle because I read a quote of yours and it was almost exactly a quote that I got from Ed Shaughnessy years ago, and it was about if you look out there and at least some of the people aren't moving or tapping your feet, you're not doing your job.

DG: You're not doing your job, that's right. Yeah. Yeah, Basie said the same thing. That's right. That's right.

MR: Here's a hard question, and I thought of it because I just attended a research presentation by a student here and she wrote a paper, she was doing research basically on women in

jazz, and partially race, but she was mostly focusing on gender. But in your opinion, in today's scene, does it make a difference if a young musician trying to get into the business is African-American or Caucasian or Asian? Does it make a difference these days?

DG: No. No, I don't think it makes a difference. You're speaking specifically to jazz?

MR: Yes.

DG: No. I believe that everybody, no matter where they come from, has something to contribute. And jazz has been given to the world as America's contribution to the world of music you know. And African-Americans are the people that gave this music, that offered this music through the borders of America to the world. And so now it has become an international music. And Asians are exposed to it, Europeans are exposed to it, Australians are exposed to it you know, Africans are exposed to it — it being a big difference between being African and African-American. It's two different cultures. There are many transcendental things that are similar between our two cultures, but still it's two different cultures. And so when jazz is being exposed to Africans, those inherent African things that are similar can come out but there is still some differences, like [scats] the ride cymbal beat is right in tune with the six-eight feel that you hear in African music all the time, but it had slowed down. [rushes] one-two-three-four-five-six [scats drums]. You're gonna shuffle [scats]. Now you can break it down like that, then this is African [scats], you know, that upbeat [scats]. And those are the things that are similar, and even the bending of those pitches, you know? That wasn't done in European music. That wasn't done in American music until it came up from the music that was brought about during the time of slavery and how those field hollars and work songs, how those bent pitches started to work themselves into the fabric of American music, you know. And so a lot of different things that I think — I think I'm kind of going off on a tangent here — but there are many different — because jazz is now an American music — sorry — jazz is now an international music, those people who are being exposed to it are now able to contribute to it you know. And you don't have to be a non-African-American in order to contribute to it. I don't believe that at all.

MR: Okay. That's a good answer. And I see you're fairly — you had mentioned before having an IT person. And it looks to me like you're fairly techno-hip. You're offering lessons by Skype.

DG: Uh huh, yeah, right.

MR: It's like almost a necessity now, isn't it.

DG: Yeah, that's right, that's right, that's right. You know I also mentioned earlier in this interview about the fact that there are ways around — not having to use a record company in order to get your music out there. That ties in with that you know. The

internet has become an incredible resource for musicians and we have to learn how to manipulate the internet in order to make our small business a successful one. Because as a musician you essentially are starting your own small business and you are the product. So you have to use the internet in a way of marketing/publicity, and you have to use the internet as far as getting your music out there in the way of distribution. Prior to the internet the only way you could get your music out there was to go through a distribution company, most times those distribution companies only associated themselves with record labels. If you came to a distribution company as an individual they wouldn't even look at you because you wouldn't have a catalogue of products to offer them. So then you looked to the record companies and tried to sign with them so you could become part of their catalogue. Well they have their own set list of criteria in order for you to get signed. So those of us who haven't been signed onto a record label, you have to kind of fend for yourself. And then the internet comes along and you say oh wait a minute. Now we can — I can produce my own product, pay for the musician fees and get a nice package ready to go for physical distribution, and I can take that CD and also digitally upload it to my website, and also to other sites like CD Baby or there are other companies like CD Baby as well. Also divert traffic through Reverb Nation and Facebook, and have all these other sites act to divert traffic to your website so they can then find out everything about you the artist and get them interested in your music. And there are some artists that have been very successful at doing that. Prince — the R&B and soul artist — he was probably one of the first ones to really manipulate the internet early in its infancy. He had a huge record deal with Warner Brothers. And after all the success he had with "Purple Rain" —

MR: "Little Red Corvette."

DG: "Little Red Corvette" and all that stuff. He said, you know I don't have to be controlled by this big conglomerate of Warner Brothers. I can do this myself. And so he started his own record label and got a person to manipulate the internet for him, and with his name being pretty much household, he was able to draw people to his website and sell music directly through his own website and the money goes directly to him. So it is possible. And we have to figure out how to do this.

MR: Yeah. And even some of the middle-aged jazz artists I guess I would say, who have record labels, most of them are not happy with their record labels.

DG: Correct. Yeah, yeah, yeah, yeah. I was just talking with a friend of mine earlier today about this, a trumpeter named Pharez Whitted. And he recently took his project to a company called Origin Records, where he can — I think you pay them a fee of about four or five thousand dollars and they'll package your product and so you get good artwork in the packaging; they will do the publicity and the radio promo for a good maybe four to six week run, maybe an eight week run of promo; and they have international

distribution. All for four or five grand. And those — you pay more than that, a record company, because they don't have all that in-house so they will pay more than that for all those services. So that's a pretty good deal. So there are ways of doing this without going the traditional route of sending in your CD to a record label with the promo kit and everything — will you sign me? So, yeah.

MR: Yeah. It would be unlikely these days. Well sometimes I like to play a tune for folks and get their take on it. So of all the things, the myriad of things I could pick, I'm going to try this out on you and see what you think.

[audio interlude]

From what you said it sounds like something your father would have liked.

DG: Yup, yup.

[inaudible]

The title tune that's being played and the instrumentation already narrows it down to essentially a few people.

Okay. I'm going to take a stab at this.

[inaudible]

This is one of the later versions of Cannonball Adderley's Quintet.

MR: That's right.

DG: Yeah. I say later because he's doing some things in there that I have never heard him doing back in the earlier versions of that quintet. He sounds like this is from the early seventies I'm guessing.

MR: Well this is from the "Mercy Mercy" LP. And it's a Nat composition.

DG: Yeah, yeah. Okay. That's definitely Nat. I knew that from the first couple of notes.

MR: How come? You know —

DG: Well I'm a trumpet player, you know?

MR: I know but it's so funny you say that because the guys that I was fortunate enough to talk to, like Sweets Edison and that generation, they make such a thing out of that. Like "in my day you could tell a player in two measures." Now you just said the same thing. Can you put it into words? Or maybe —

DG: Well with Nat I would have to say it's — well the dead giveaway would be his tone. Because he is playing cornet, and the cornet is strikingly different than the trumpet. Most trumpeters can hear the difference right off you know. The cornet has a much mellower sound, and he's — well I was going to say he's playing it like a trumpet. I mean he's playing it like a trumpeter would play a trumpet, you know? And all that stuff that he's — and then beyond that, beyond the sound of the horn, you have all these Natisms that are his congregation of notes. But the same thing — I was able to tell the same thing with Cannonball much later when he went up into the high register and, what is it, and

distorted the notes when he went up into the higher register, and then a run that he did where it was his full tone [scats] but it was just a full huge tone, and it felt like he was blowing the brass off the horn. And I said, oh that's Cannonball. I know that. That's Cannon. Now the saxophonist like yourself, I'm sure you'd be able to —

MR: Well he's my hero.

DG: Oh yeah. You'd be able to tell from the first couple of notes you know, oh that's Cannonball. And in the beginning of that he was doing some non-Cannonballish things, to my ears, just because of my lack of knowledge of this part of Cannonball's playing. But as it went on, that's when I said okay, that's Cannonball, yeah.

MR: Well, you know, and part and parcel with sort of the older generation talking about individuality, a lot of them would also say that nowadays everybody sounds the same, because they're all using the same books, etcetera. And do you agree with that and if so what do you do about it?

DG: I totally agree with it.

MR: As a teacher.

DG: Well you know you have to sound like someone in order to sound like yourself. In the beginning of, in the formative years of your being able to play at an advanced skill level in improvisation, you'd want to sound like somebody else. Like Dizzy Gillespie sounded like Roy Eldridge in those early years. Miles Davis sounded like Dizzy in his early years. And Lee Morgan sounded like Clifford Brown in his early years you know. So when they eventually got tired of playing that way they started going into their own direction. I don't think that's happening so much now. You know I hear a lot of the — not just trumpet but even on other instruments — I hear a lot of the younger generation staying in the nest from which they were born you know. A lot of trumpeters are infatuated with Freddie Hubbard, as am I. I will be the first to say that I will have some Freddieisms that will come out in my playing. But I like to think that I have matriculated into something else, you know, and I gauge that by people who say to me, "man I heard this trumpeter on the radio the other day, and I said 'man, that sounds like Gardner, man, it sounded like Derrick.'" And sure enough, when the guy announced the tune, it was you, man. I said wow. Okay. But that means that I'm suddenly coming into my own sound you know. And he didn't say it sounded just like Freddie Hubbard, or you sounded just like Clifford Brown you know, which thank you for even associating me to those cats you know. But you have to graduate into your own thing. And I think that that's what players nowadays have to start pushing for. You can't just sound like Cannonball forever. You can't sound like Freddie Hubbard forever. You can't sound like Paul Chambers or Ron Carter forever. You've got to use that as a launching pad into what you're trying to get into, into your own voice.

MR: Well said. I'm just going to take a crack and run a few names by you. Joe Wilder?

DG: Oh wow, wow. Probably one of the most consummate trumpet players to ever live. And one of the most versatile trumpeters as well. Not only in jazz but also in classical music. And versatile to the point where he's able to accept a gig within the classical circle. He's played — he was one of the first trumpeters to — I won't say one of the first black trumpeters to play in this — but he was one of the first black trumpeters to choose to play on Broadway, back during the time when there was plenty of work to go around in other jazz circles. He was playing Broadway gigs in the pit orchestras. And such a fabulous style of playing as well. He is able to — he plays, and I'm very careful with trumpeters or musicians of his generation. Because you think that they play in just the older style of improvisation, they play in more of the swing style you know, of improvisation of jazz. But if you had him play on something like "Footprints" or "ESP" or something like that, he will throw something out at you that he played thirty, forty years ago, that fits. And you'll just be like whoa, where did that come from? This happened to me — well I learned this from my father. My father is another trumpeter that I respect hugely. And I always say that I put my trumpet in the case when he plays. You know, I get out the pad and pencil and take notes. I discovered Clifford Brown through him. That was his man, Clifford Brown. But I was playing a Broadway show that went to Europe. It is called "Black and Blue." And we were in Germany. We were in Hamburg I believe. And Monday nights is the dark night for Broadway shows, there's no show on Monday night. So we found a little place in town where we could play on Monday nights. And it was a place called the Dennis Swing Club I think. I think it's since closed now. But we were playing there on a Monday night and the cat who was playing second trumpet to me, his name was Irv Stokes.

MR: Irv Stokes.

DG: Irv Stokes. You might recognize that name. He played a lot with Lou Donaldson. And a fabulous trumpet player of that older generation. And I'd always played a lot of swing gigs with him you know. And he would just nail it to the wall. So we got to the jam session on Monday night and we were getting all modern playing "Footprints" and "Giant Steps" and all of this stuff, and all of these tunes, uptempo, and stuff like "Just in Time" and what's another tune like proving ground tunes —

MR: "Cherokee?"

DG: "Cherokee." And he comes in and he gets up and plays and he just falls right in. And then we played something like — I think we played "Footprints." And he just switched like a light bulb and started playing this other way and everything he played just fit right into the chord changes, right into the vibe of the tune, and we were all like whoa, where did this side of Irv come from? We didn't know he even played like this. And the whole time

he was playing I had my note pad and I would say oh, oh really, oh wow. So I learned. So okay Sonny boy, in class today we are going to learn this.

MR: How about Joe Williams?

DG: Joe Williams. Oh man. It was such a — I felt like I was in school the entire time when we got the chance to perform with Joe Williams along with the Basie band. We did several tours with him. And wow. His sense of phrasing and timing, and the way that he just treats a tune was impeccable. Every note and every lyric that he sang was perfectly placed. Almost like he was reading from a page. And he was able to take an audience and just put the audience right in his hand, and the whole audience is just like that — just waiting. He had total command of the audience. There was one tune that Shirley Horn made famous, called "Here's to Life," man. And Joe Williams did it. And Joe just tore it up, really did such a beautiful job with it. And the audience was just — you could hear a pin drop. And so I definitely learned to take my time by listening to him. I was able to learn the meaning of the tune through him, because the way that he sang it was like he was telling you a story you know. So oh that's what the tune's about. And a lot of times instrumentalists just get into the notes. Just when you learn tunes, just learn notes. You don't learn the lyrics of the tune and find out what the tune is about you know. And upon hearing Joe sing these tunes I'm learning what the tune is about — not in the manner that he's singing it to me but more like he's telling a story. But then we haven't even talked about the blues yet. That's a whole nother thing. This was just a whole graduate mini-course on how to sing the blues. If you need any help with doing that, go to Joe Williams.

MR: You know, we've got to get you to your thing. But this has really been fascinating. And one of the best kinds of compliments a person gets is somebody that wasn't drawn out. One of my saxophone students, Brett, who played with you on the jam session last night, and he said "I really liked that guy. He didn't play a gazillion notes like some of the other people, and every note seemed to mean something." He said that about you.

DG: Wow.

MR: I think that's a high compliment because he's a person who listens to a lot of music in addition to playing himself.

DG: Sure. Wow. Okay. I'll have to send him his check.

MR: Well it's really been nice talking to you. I look forward to hearing you tonight with the band.

DG: Oh sure thing. Thank you. And it's a wonderful interview, and I'm glad to be part of it.

MR: All right. Thanks a lot.

DG: Thank you.